

Instructor Notes – Activity 2: The Art of the Prompt

Overview

Purpose: Help participants move from “I just type something in the box” to **deliberately designing prompts**. Show that adding **context, role, action, format, and constraints** dramatically improves AI output quality.

Key messages:

- Small changes in the prompt → **big changes** in relevance and quality.
 - Prompts are design artefacts, not throwaway sentences.
 - Activity 2 builds directly on Activity 1’s prompts (summary/announcement/quiz).
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Suggested Flow (15 minutes)

- **3–4 minutes** – **Live demo:** vague vs structured prompt.
 - **7–8 minutes** – **Hands-on “prompt makeover”:** they improve their own prompts from Activity 1.
 - **3–4 minutes** – **Quick share & link to critique (Activity 3).**
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Live Demo: Vague vs Structured (3–4 minutes)

Use a teaching-focused example.

- **Vague prompt:**

Give me some teaching ideas about marketing.

- **Structured prompt:**

You are an experienced marketing educator.

I teach a **second-year** unit on **consumer behaviour** with about **120 students** in tutorials of 25.

Suggest **3 in-class activities (15–20 minutes each)** to help students apply the concept of **[concept]** to real-world examples.

For each activity, provide:

- A brief description
- Materials needed
- Clear instructions I can read out loud
- One debrief question to link back to theory

Ask the room:

- “What’s better about the second one?”
- “What changed in the prompt?”

Then name the pattern (pick your preferred label):

- **CONTEXT + ROLE + ACTION + FORMAT + TONE/CONSTRAINTS**
 - Or CRAFT (Context, Role, Action, Format, Tone/Target).
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Hands-On: Prompt Makeover (7–8 minutes)

Instructions to participants:

1. **Copy one prompt** you used in Activity 1 (even if it was messy).
 - e.g. the prompt they used to get a summary, announcement, quiz, or rewritten brief.
2. Underneath it, **rewrite the prompt** using:
 - **CONTEXT** – course, year level, discipline, constraints
 - **ROLE** – e.g. “You are a learning designer...”
 - **ACTION** – what you want AI to do
 - **FORMAT** – bullets, table, slides, email, etc.
 - **TONE / CONSTRAINTS** – length, level, formality.
3. Run **both** prompts and compare the outputs:
 - Which is more on-target?
 - Which saves you more time?
 - What changed in the prompt that made the difference?

If you want to weave in **Prompt Coach/Copilot**:

“Paste your original prompt into Prompt Coach / Copilot and ask:
‘Help me improve this prompt so it’s clearer and more specific for [goal].’
Then refine it yourself.”

Emphasise that Prompt Coach is an **assistant**, not the centrepiece – they still need to apply judgement.

Extra Prompt Patterns You Can Offer

Use these as “ready-to-steal” patterns for people who finish quickly or want more examples.

A. Feedback Helper with Guardrails

You are an experienced university lecturer.

CONTEXT: I teach [discipline], [year level]. This is **formative feedback**, not a final grade.

ACTION: Help me draft feedback on the following student work:

[paste short excerpt]

CONSTRAINTS:

- Start with one positive comment.
- Then give **2–3 specific, actionable suggestions**.
- Do **not** assign a mark or grade.
- Use supportive, professional language.

B. Rubric Refiner

You are a learning designer who specialises in assessment.

CONTEXT: This is a rubric for a [year level] unit in [discipline].

ACTION: Improve the wording of these criteria so they are:

- Clear to students
- Focused on observable behaviours
- Distinct between performance levels

FORMAT: Return the revised rubric as a markdown table with columns: “**Criterion**”, “**High**”, “**Mid**”, “**Low**”.

RUBRIC:

[paste existing rubric]

C. Misconception Diagnostic

You are a university teacher designing a short diagnostic activity.

CONTEXT: Students in my [year level, discipline] unit often misunderstand [concept].

ACTION:

- Propose **3 quick questions or tasks** that are likely to reveal common misconceptions about this concept.
- For each, include: the question/task, the misconception it tests for, and what a strong response would show.

FORMAT: Bullet points.

These patterns highlight that **changing the prompt structure changes the kind of thinking AI supports**.

Summary Pattern for Slides

You can summarise Activity 2 on a slide like this:

- **Goal:** Upgrade prompts → upgrade automation quality.
- **Demo:** Vague vs structured (Context + Role + Action + Format + Constraints).
- **Hands-on:** Improve your Activity 1 prompt and compare outputs.
- **Takeaway line:**

“Activity 1 showed that AI can **automate the tedious**.

Activity 2 shows that if we **upgrade our prompts**, we upgrade the quality of that automation.”

Connections to Other Activities

- **From Activity 1:** They already have prompts and outputs (summaries, announcements, quizzes). Activity 2 **refines the prompts** that produced those outputs.
- **To Activity 3:** The improved outputs become excellent material for the **5-step critique** – they can now ask: *“Is this better output actually good enough to use?”*
- **To later practice:** The same prompt patterns can be used for feedback, rubrics, activity design, research prompts, and professional communications.